a single major legitimising force of the new order.'[90]

The transition process in Eastern Europe was taking place at a time when societies in the West had long ago moved beyond the concept of the nation-state as the main source of a state's legitimacy. In such a context, the new patriotism in Eastern Europe after 1990 was not always easy to comprehend. It often appeared out of touch with the spirit of the time in the rest of Europe. The drive to establish new nation-states by those small nations that had not had the chance to do so earlier in their histories (for example, in the nineteenth century that saw the creation of Germany and Italy) was, in the early 1990s, often misunderstood in Western Europe as an expression of a will to fragment, a movement towards what has been portrayed as Balkanisation (one of those political terms wrongly associated with the Balkans[91]). The counter argument – that only sovereign nations can decide on joining transnational or intergovernmental organisations like the EU – did not sound strong enough, both because the world had, at the time, moved beyond traditional concepts of sovereignty and because most of these nations had only very limited experience, if any, of being a sovereign nation.

Furthermore, lurking timidly behind these developments and almost undetected at the time (conservative and Christian democratic parties in Europe were then at their full strength, and they were the ones that offered the most enthusiastic support to new political parties in the East) was also the region's social conservatism, to which I shall return in the following chapter, and to which national identity was of central importance. Part of the reason that, at the time, this social profile largely went unnoticed was also the equally and passionately pro-European character of the newly emerged political forces in Central Europe. For them, the return to Europe was a natural part of their staunch anti-Communism or anti-Soviet attitude.

Indeed, the new states from Central and Eastern Europe, once they joined the EU, became some of its most devoted members – at least that was the spirit in the 2000s and probably still in the early 2010s. There was a good reason for that: for the peoples and governments of Central and Eastern Europe the enlargement of 2004 was not (only) an enlargement of an already existing union. For them, it was a re-creation of a more wholesome Europe, one which could not exist without them, a return to the realities before Yalta and the Iron Curtain. It was also a confirmation of their